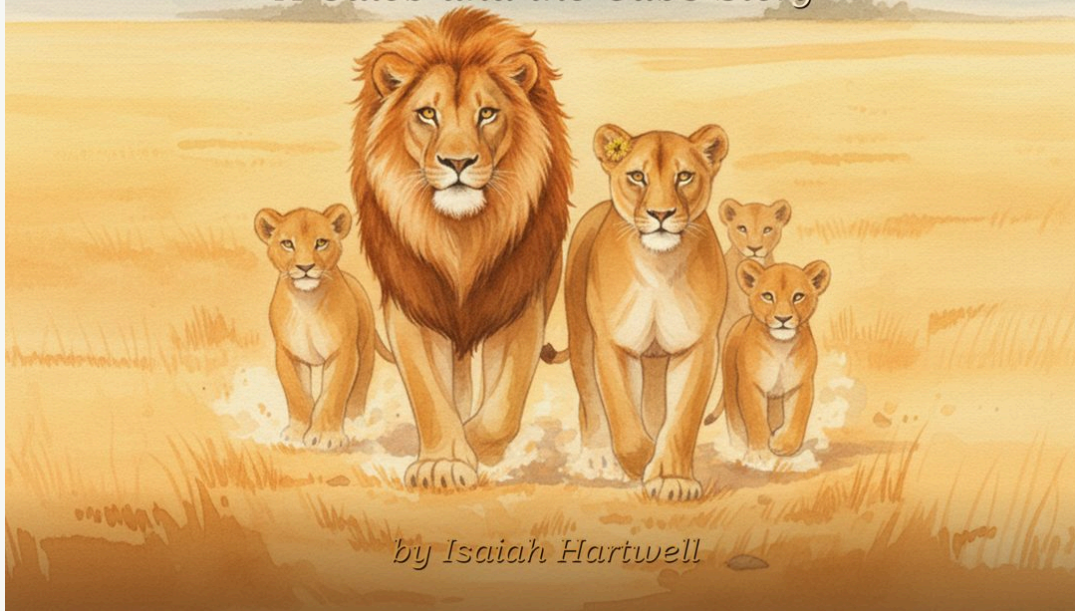


THE KINGDOM OF JUDEA

THE LONG WALK

A Caleb and the Cubs Story



by Isaiah Hartwell

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The Kingdom of Judea · Book Two

Made Out of Clay Productions

God's Love Never Fails

by Isaiah Hartwell

For our son, Clayton



The morning was new,
and so was everything else.
Hebron Ridge had gone small behind them —
not gone, not forgotten,
just smaller and smaller,
until it was a thin gold line against the sky.
Caleb walked in front, the way he always walked.
His shoulder carried a hurt from the last morning at home.
He did not speak of it.
Neither did Hannah.
She walked behind him, humming her mother's song,
and the cubs walked close behind her —
Ezra and Leah and Asher and Tirzah.
Tirzah kept looking back over her shoulder.
Then she stopped looking back,
and looked forward instead,
like her brothers and her sister.
The walk had begun.



The sun was high and hot.
The path was long.
The land grew stranger with every step.
Tirzah tugged her father's leg.
"Papa. Where are we going?"
Caleb looked out at the far edge of the world.
"Judea."
Ezra stopped walking.
"Judea? Papa — no lion we know
has ever even seen Judea."
Leah was right behind him.
"And what about my friends?
What am I supposed to do now?
I had a whole life back there."
Caleb did not answer right away.
He looked at his son.
He looked at his daughter.
He looked at the sky.
Then, soft and steady:
"We are going because that is where we are supposed to be."
"Says who?" Ezra asked.
"God."
"How do you know?"
Caleb let out one long, slow breath.
"I don't know what we will find there.
I don't know yet what He is asking of us.
I only know He has put it on my heart —
the way you know rain is coming
before one drop falls.
I have faith.
And today, faith is the path."
Ezra went very still.
Leah looked at the dust.
Hannah rested her paw on Caleb's good shoulder.
And the family kept walking.



At the first rest, in the shade of one thin tree,
Hannah gathered the cubs close,
the way she had on the last night at home.
"The song," she said. "Again.
It walks with us now."
She closed her eyes,
and the three small lines came out, soft as breath:
God is near.
God is here.
God's love never fails.
Ezra said it this time, all the way through.
Leah pretended not to — and said it anyway.
Asher said it twice, loud, in case God was far.
Tirzah whispered it into the small place inside her
where she kept the things she loved.
Six voices. One song.
It was starting to sound like a family.



The land changed the way new lands do.

The rocks grew sharper.

The wind found a new voice and tried it out all day.

Asher told a joke,
then told it again, louder.

It did not get better.

He laughed anyway —
and Tirzah laughed because he did.

Caleb's family walked on.



Then came a day with not enough in it.
Not enough food.
Not enough water.
Not enough shade in the whole hot land.
That evening, Tirzah cried —
very, very quietly,
trying with all her small might not to be heard.
She was heard.
That night, Caleb gathered everyone close
and laid one big paw, gently, on each cub's back —
one, two, three, four.
And the family said the song together:
God is near.
God is here.
God's love never fails.
The sky did not answer.
But something inside each of them
heard back.
Small paws, brave hearts —
that was the whole family, walking.



Before dawn,
when the sky was the color of a held breath,
Caleb walked out alone.
He looked at the long land ahead.
He looked at the hurt in his shoulder.
He looked up at the last few stars.
"Lord," he whispered —
just to the wind,
just for himself —
"did I do right?"
The wind moved through the dry grass.
The wind said nothing at all.
Caleb stood there a long time anyway.
Then he turned back toward his sleeping family —
and that was his answer.
He picked it up,
and kept walking.



Ezra walked behind his father, watching.
He watched the way Caleb's shoulder dipped.
He watched the limp his father hid from Hannah —
and the way Hannah looked away just in time
to let it stay hidden.
Inside his head, Ezra turned the days over and over,
like a stone he could not see all the sides of.
The leader.
The order.
The hurt.
Judea.
Some of it did not fit yet.
There has to be a better way, he thought.
There is always a better way.
I just have to find it.
Ezra was the thinker.
He did not have the answer.
But one day — not today, not tomorrow —
he would.
He walked on.



Leah walked at the very back of the line.

She chose the very back.

From there she could watch the road behind them.

From there she could see her whole family at once,

and nothing could come at them

that she would not see first.

The hurt she carried did not have a name yet.

She was young.

She would not show it. Not to anyone.

I'm not afraid, she told herself,

the way she told herself every day now —

quietly, completely,

like a vow.

She walked at the back of her family

like someone who had decided

that no one was ever going to hurt them again.

She walked there

all the way to the new land.



On the longest, hottest afternoon,
Asher saw Tirzah's paws begin to drag.
He didn't say a word.
He just dipped his shoulder,
gathered her gently up onto his back,
and kept walking.
"Roaring-buddy ride," he whispered.
Tirzah — who had been about to cry —
laughed instead.
Asher carried his little sister
the whole rest of that afternoon
and did not complain once.
Some strength lives in the shoulders.
Some strength lives deeper down.
Gentle is strong.



That night, Tirzah lay close against Hannah
and asked the question she had carried all day.

"Mama. How do we walk so far?"

Hannah brushed her nose against Tirzah's ear.

"One paw at a time, my little lion.

That is how far gets walked.

Not two paws. Not ten paws.

One paw.

Then the next one.

Then the one after that.

And God walks every single paw with you."

Tirzah nodded, already half asleep.

"One paw," she whispered.

"One paw," Hannah whispered back.



Then came a morning the family did not see coming.
They climbed a low, rocky hill —
just one more hill, in a land made of hills —
and at the top, they stopped.
Below them,
wide as a held breath,
green as a kept promise,
lay a valley unlike any land they had crossed.
Soft rolling hills.
Wild grapevines climbing the acacia trees.
Grass grown green under kinder rains.
Water shining in more places than one.
No old pride.
No old leader.
No high stone.
Just this.
Caleb stood very still.
Hannah's paw found his.
"Vine Hills," Hannah said, very low.
She said it the way you say amen.
"Vine Hills," Caleb said.
This was Judea — the land God had called them to.
And this green valley in its heart,
they named Vine Hills.
The cubs looked at the land.
And the land — green and wide and waiting —
looked back.



Down the hill and into the valley,
together,
walked Caleb's family.

They did not know what was waiting for them there.

They did not know how hard the building would be.

They did not know that one day — far from now —
a kingdom would rise in this called land

and take its name:

Judea.

They knew only the song:

God is near.

God is here.

God's love never fails.

So in they walked.

One paw at a time.



They found the hollow just before dark —
a den-shaped place in the rocks.
Hannah paced its corners
and began the long work of making it home.
Leah stood watch at the mouth
until the first stars came out.
Ezra found the driest corner
and lay down where the wind could not reach the little ones.
Asher could find nothing useful to do at all —
so he did the most useful thing of all.
He made Tirzah laugh.
Caleb watched his family
fill the strange den with familiar sounds.
And the hurt in his shoulder —
the one he had carried all the way from the high stone —
ached a little less tonight.
Some hurts begin to ease
only once you are finally somewhere safe.
"Thank You," he whispered.
It was the whole prayer.
It was enough.



Night came down over Vine Hills,
soft and wide and full of new sounds.
One by one, the lions slept.
Papa first — tired deepest.
Then Ezra. Then Leah. Then Asher.
Hannah lay still in the dark,
the way mothers lie still:
listening.
And in the smallest corner of the den,
two small eyes were still open wide.
The new dark was a bigger dark.
Bigger than Tirzah's brave.
Bigger than her.
"Mama?"
Quiet paws came close,
and Tirzah pressed her face into her mother's fur.
"I miss the old den, Mama."
She had been so careful not to say it.
But it came out the way true things do.
Hannah went very still.
She did not say be brave.
She did not say this is our den now.
She did not say you'll get used to it.
She said — quietly, truly —
"I miss it too, sweet girl.
I miss it too."
For a long, soft while, they lay there together —
two lionesses, one big, one small,
missing the same place.
Then Hannah brushed her nose against Tirzah's ear,
right beside the small pink flower
that had come all the way from the old country.
"God hears even a little roar, my little lion.
Say the song with me —
right into this new dark."
Together, almost too soft to hear:
God is near.
God is here.
God's love never fails.
The new walls did not turn into the old walls.
But something inside Tirzah —
something pulled tight all the way from the old land —
let go.
Mama was there. Papa was there.
Brothers and sister were there.
And God was there.
"Hush now," Hannah whispered.
"God keeps watch."
Tirzah closed her eyes —
and slept.



If your walk is long tonight,
if the road is wild,
if you do not know yet
where God is taking you —

walk anyway.

Soft and steady.

One paw at a time.

And say it as you go,
the way Caleb's family said it
all the way to Judea:

God is near.

God is here.

God's love never fails.

Whatever God is preparing —

He is already there,
waiting for you.
